

Few, a few, little, and a little

Teaching guide

Express a small amount with the intended emphasis.

Understand the distinction

Use few and a few for small numbers of countable plural nouns. Use little and a little for small amounts of an uncountable noun. Few/little often stress a shortage; a few/a little stress that some are available.

Context decides whether an amount is enough. A few does not promise a sufficient number. Little can also be an adjective meaning small, as in little houses or little people; that is a different use from the quantity word.

Compare the patterns

SMALL NUMBER

I have a few questions.

There are some questions.

SHORTAGE

We have little time.

The speaker emphasizes the small amount.

SOME AVAILABLE

We have a little time.

The speaker emphasizes that some time remains.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose for an amount: a little advice / a few advice

- A. a little advice
- B. a few advice
- C. a little advices

2. Which usually sounds more positive: few friends / a few friends?

- A. few friends
- B. Both always communicate exactly the same attitude.
- C. a few friends

3. Must little houses mean a small number of houses?

- A. Yes. Little always counts how many houses there are.
- B. No. It normally means small houses.
- C. No. It normally means expensive houses.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which sentence correctly expresses a small amount of time tonight and a shortage of free hours this week?

- A. I have a little time this evening, but little free hours this week.
- B. I have a little time this evening, but few free hours this week.
- C. I have a few time this evening, but few free hours this week.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. a little advice

Advice is normally uncountable.

B: Advice is normally uncountable; use a little advice or a few pieces of advice.

C: Do not add a plural ending to advice in this use.

2. C. a few friends

It emphasizes having some friends.

A: Few often emphasizes a shortage; a few emphasizes that some exist.

B: Adding a often changes the emphasis from a shortage to a small positive amount.

3. B. No. It normally means small houses.

Little can describe physical size.

A: Little before houses normally describes their size.

C: Little describes small size, not price.

4. B. I have a little time this evening, but few free hours this week.

A little goes with uncountable time; few emphasizes a shortage of countable hours.

A: Hours is countable and plural, so use few for the shortage.

C: Time is uncountable here, so use a little.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-27.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which sentence correctly expresses a small amount of time tonight and a shortage of free hours this week?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.